



Huh???... Your Toes Are Supposed to Be Able to Do What???

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It's Personal

Y'all... I just learned something weird – You are supposed to be able to wiggle and 'splay' your toes independently!! And you may be asking *"Why do I need to be able to do this?"* Well, it is all about balance. You see, **our toes are crucial to how steady we are on our feet** – especially as we age.

I came across this interesting tidbit of information while researching osteopenia and osteoporosis, and felt this deserved to be researched further. You see, as we age, we tend to be less steady on our feet, have a slower reaction time, and... *here's the BIG one...* shuffling our feet a bit to prevent falling. *(Oh joy! Feeling our age is showing in how we walk and maintain steadiness and balance!!)* This is why balance training is one of the most important parts of osteoporosis prevention. It helps:

- prevent hip fractures, which often result from falls,
- and balance ability also predicts fracture risk surprisingly well.

It is the very reason physical therapists focus on feet, ankles, and posture just as much as the bone density itself. So, I was thinking, *"What if we could help our bodies, especially our feet and toes stay nimble (or as nimble as possible) and strong as we age?"* Here's what I found... So, let's dive in and take a look!

First, Let's Talk About Balance

(Balance? What balance? I have been a klutz all my life!! Ok...I hear ya! Keep reading to see why toe exercises are so important for balance and it may help you overcome some of that klutziness!) Balance is supported by a complex interaction between the brain, nervous system, muscles, joints, bones, eyes, ears, and feet. The toes play an important role by helping sense the ground, stabilize the body, and make constant postural adjustments during standing and walking. Healthy arches, ankles, hips, core muscles, and leg strength also contribute to proper alignment and balance control. In addition, strong bones are important because osteopenia and osteoporosis may contribute to postural changes, altered gait, spinal degeneration, and reduced stability, all of which may increase fall risk. [5,6]

Y'all the brain and nervous system continuously process information from three major systems involved in balance: the visual system (eyes), the vestibular system (inner ear), and the proprioceptive system, which includes sensory nerves in the muscles, joints, feet, and toes. [7] The inner ear detects head position and movement, while the eyes help orient the body in space. Sensory receptors in the feet and toes provide constant feedback regarding pressure, surface changes, and body position. When any of these systems become impaired — including nerve dysfunction, muscle weakness, diabetes, vestibular disorders, poor vision, or bone and joint degeneration — balance, coordination, and stability may decline. [5–8] *(In this discussion, I am going to focus on just the feet and toes. So, keep reading and learn why and how to wiggle dem toes for better balance! 😊)*



The Foot-Brain Connection:

(You may not realize it, but your feet and brain are constantly talking to each other!) One reason balance often worsens with aging is that the “foot-brain connection” gradually weakens. The feet contain thousands of sensory receptors that continuously send information to the brain about:

- pressure,
- surface changes,
- body position,
- posture,
- and movement.

This communication helps the brain make rapid balance corrections while standing, walking, or reacting to uneven surfaces. As we age, however, the small muscles in the feet may weaken, toes stiffen, nerve function declines, and sensory feedback becomes less efficient. These changes may contribute to:

- shuffling gait,
- slower reaction time,
- instability,
- reduced coordination,
- and increased fall risk.

(Y'all! Guess what? If your feet stop sending clear signals, your brain cannot react as quickly to keep you steady!!) Thankfully, the body still has an impressive ability to adapt and respond to training as we age. Exercises that strengthen the feet and toes while improving balance, mobility, and sensory awareness may help “wake up” this foot-brain communication system and improve stability over time. That is one reason physical therapists often focus heavily on feet, ankles, posture, and gait training during fall-prevention programs.

Signs of Weakening Feet and Toes

(Ok let's look at our feet and our toes! Really look at them!!) Believe it or not, your feet and toes are tiny biomechanical superheroes. Together they help stabilize the body, support balance, absorb shock, propel movement, and assist with posture and gait. Unfortunately, years of cramped footwear, inactivity, aging, diabetes, nerve dysfunction, poor balance, and/or weakened foot muscles may gradually reduce foot and toe strength, flexibility, and coordination. [8,11]

Common signs of weakening feet and toes may include:

- difficulty spreading the toes apart, *(It's not the end of the world if you were never able to do this!)*
- inability to lift the big toe independently,
- toe cramping or curling,
- collapsing arches,
- poor balance,
- foot fatigue,



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- frequent stumbling,
- ankle instability,
- slower walking speed,
- reduced push-off strength,
- clawing or hammertoes,
- numbness or tingling,
- or feeling unsteady while barefoot. [8]

Some people also notice they grip the floor with their toes while walking or standing, which may signal compensation for weakness or instability elsewhere in the feet, ankles, hips, or the body's core.

Weak feet and toes may also affect posture and skeletal alignment over time. The intrinsic foot muscles help support the arches, stabilize the ankles, absorb impact, and provide sensory feedback to the brain regarding body position and movement. [8,11] When these muscles weaken, gait mechanics and balance reactions may become less efficient, potentially increasing the risk of falling — especially in individuals with osteopenia, osteoporosis, diabetes, peripheral neuropathy, or age-related muscle loss. [8] *(We still have time to wake up those sleeping baby piggies and improve toe strength and our balance! So, let's do it!)*

If My Toes Don't Spread Dramatically, Are My Feet Dysfunctional?

(I am glad you asked!! No, they ARE NOT dysfunctional.) To be honest, many adults have limited independent toe control and reduced ability to spread ("splay") their toes apart. In fact, it is common for adults to move all the toes together, struggle to lift only the big toe, or demonstrate minimal intrinsic foot muscle control. While researchers do not yet have standardized measurements for normal toe independence, podiatry literature and clinical observation suggest that toe mobility and coordination often decline with aging, inactivity, restrictive footwear, diabetes, arthritis, prior foot surgery, nerve stiffness (neural tension), and altered gait mechanics. [8,11] These changes may contribute to weakened balance reactions, impaired foot stability, altered walking mechanics, and increased fall risk over time. Years of wearing narrow shoes that compress the toes may further reduce natural toe splay and intrinsic foot muscle activation, particularly in older adults. [8,9]

Wait! What is Nerve Stiffness/Neural Tension?

(Ok! Ok, I'll try not to get too techy on this topic.) Neural tension, sometimes called "nerve stiffness," refers to reduced mobility or increased sensitivity of a nerve as it moves through surrounding tissues. In the feet and toes, symptoms may include burning, tingling, numbness, cramping, weakness, altered balance, or a feeling of toe "stiffness" despite minimal arthritis. [1,2] *(Since I just completed a discussion on the "Osteos", I wanted to include this next tidbit of information too!)* Osteopenia and osteoporosis may contribute indirectly because bone loss can alter posture, gait, spinal alignment, foot stability, and muscle strength, increasing stress on the tibial nerve and related structures. [1,3] *(I hope you caught that! It is another reason to keep our bones in tip-top shape with a healthy diet and exercise to support our 'frame' as we age!!*





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Researchers now understand that nerves are not static ‘wires.’ They are living tissues that move and stretch with the body. [2] Flat feet, altered gait mechanics, ankle dorsiflexion, diabetes, and age-related degeneration may increase tibial nerve tension and contribute to chronic foot symptoms, impaired toe mobility, and peripheral neuropathy. [1–4] Speaking of diabetes, it is also a major contributor because elevated glucose may damage nerve fibers and impair circulation to the nerves, increasing the risk of peripheral neuropathy, altered toe sensation, weakness, and reduced neural mobility. [2,4]

Is That a Torture Chamber on Your Feet?

(By the way ladies... Let’s talk about those shoes! You know the ones that scrunch and torture ‘your little piggies’ so tight that they squeal in pain or give no support to your heels or the ball of your foot, shortening the ligaments in the back of your calves causing an excruciating Charlie-horse at night? Yep... those favourite sexy shoes!) For decades, women have squeezed their feet into pointy stilettos like Cinderella’s stepsisters trying to force a size 10 foot into a size 5 glass slipper. Fashion may have promised elegance, but many high heels and narrow toe-box shoes quietly reshape the feet over time. We need to face the facts: **many fashionable shoes are not doing our feet any favours.** Extremely narrow shoes and high heels may contribute to bunions, hammertoes, toe crowding, nerve irritation, shortened calf muscles, altered gait mechanics, and weakened foot stability over time. [9,10] High heels shift body weight forward onto the ball of the foot, forcing the toes into unnatural positions and changing posture and alignment from the ground up. Over time, the feet, ankles, knees, hips, pelvis, and spine may all compensate for this distorted positioning. [10] Add osteopenia or osteoporosis into the picture, and suddenly those “cute little shoes” may also increase instability and fall risk. [8] So consider this... A wider toe-box shoe is preferable and *(go ahead admit it!)* more comfortable than that cute, high heeled, narrowed toe, latest style shoe on that drop-dead gorgeous model’s foot!

(Yikes! I bet you are thinking: “I can’t give up those sexy stilettos!”) Well... we probably need to at least reduce dependence on them. They are not helping posture, balance, gait, arches, toes, or skeleton. Years of squeezing the feet into narrow toe-boxes may weaken intrinsic foot muscles, reduce natural toe splay, impair balance reactions, and increase pressure on nerves and joints. [8,9] Honestly, some of those shoes should come with a warning label and a complimentary podiatry appointment!

(Now before you start mourning the loss of your favorite stilettos, take heart...) Supportive shoes no longer have to look like they came straight out of “Granny Gumms’ orthopedic closet.” Today there are stylish options that support the foot, skeleton, posture, and balance while still looking attractive. **Better shoe choices include a stable heel, wider toe-box, cushioned sole, flexible forefoot, good arch support, and a non-slip sole.** [9,10] There are stylish, practical shoes out there for that classy lady... think Skechers *(my favourite tennies 😊)* for example. They have hands-free slip-ins with an Arch Fit option or *(get this)* Sketchers also offers the Tasteful Wedge Slip-In Casual Strappy. Think of it this way...proper footwear should allow the toes to spread naturally, provide adequate arch support, cushion impact, and help maintain balance



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without forcing the body into unnatural positions and posture. In other words, your shoes should support your skeleton — not audition for a medieval torture exhibit.

What Else Can Our Feet Including Toes Tell Us?

(This is a HUGE topic... I am going to just give you a quick highlight.) Some traditional healing systems, particularly Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM) and reflexology, propose that specific areas of the feet correspond to organs and systems throughout the body. [12] While modern science has not conclusively shown that pressing certain areas of the feet can directly diagnose or treat disease in specific organs, many people report benefits such as relaxation, stress reduction, improved body awareness, and temporary pain relief from foot therapies. [13]

Science does strongly support that the feet contain a dense network of sensory nerves, muscles, connective tissue, and pressure receptors that constantly communicate with the brain and nervous system. [7,8] The feet and toes play major roles in balance, posture, gait, shock absorption, proprioception, and movement coordination. Changes in foot strength, sensation, alignment, mobility, or toe function may sometimes reflect broader issues involving circulation, diabetes, nerve health, aging, muscle weakness, posture, or balance dysfunction. [8]

Interestingly, the Bible also places symbolic and practical importance on the feet. Scripture frequently references walking, standing firm, paths, foundations, and the guidance of one's steps. *"Stand firm then... with your feet fitted with the readiness that comes from the gospel of peace"* (Ephesians 6:13–15, NIV). Likewise, Psalm 119:105 (KJV) states, *"Thy Word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path."* In the Bible the feet are viewed not merely as body parts, but as part of one's stability, direction, strength, and daily walk-through life. *(What does all this mean? Well, your feet may not literally contain a tiny GPS system to your liver and spleen... but they absolutely are chatting with your nervous system all day long. And perhaps there is something beautifully symbolic in that. The same feet God designed to help us stand, walk, balance, and move through life are also repeatedly referenced in Scripture as part of our spiritual walk, stability, and direction. Maybe those "little piggies" deserve a little more gratitude — and a little less torture chamber footwear.)*

Whether viewed through the lens of biomechanics, neurology, ancient healing traditions, or the Biblical Word of God, the feet are far more important than most people realize. Those "little piggies" are not just along for the ride — they help support the entire body from the ground up!

You are Never Too Young to Wiggle Your Toes!!

(Have you ever watched a baby... the way they 'explore' their feet? Discover their toes? Wiggle them? Spread them? And of course, chew on them?) Well, I am not asking you to encourage chewing on toes, but I am asking parents, grandparents, and other family members to encourage children to be aware of their toes, wiggle them, splay them to help keep them strong and balanced for a lifetime. Young children naturally tend to spread their toes more, grip surfaces, squat deeply, balance better, and use the small foot muscles actively. Toddlers can be seen gripping the floor with their toes, balancing barefoot, and moving their feet very differently than most adults. Over time, many adults essentially "decondition" their feet. (/



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know I have. Now be honest...How about you? Maybe we can learn something from the kiddos around us. 😊)

We can also help children develop better foot function with 'Barefoot Play' on safe surfaces. This is done by walking barefoot on the grass (*And yes... If you live in the South, watch out for those fire ants!*), sand, uneven natural surfaces (*Sounds like 'grounding' to me - a whole other topic - which is great for reducing physical inflammation, decreasing stress hormones like cortisol, and improving sleep quality – We can all use that!*) and carpet. All of these activities help develop sensory feedback, balance reactions, and activation of the intrinsic foot muscles. Childhood activities that improve foot and toe coordination while strengthening the ankles, arches, toes, and hips include hopping, skipping, balancing, climbing, dancing, martial arts, and gymnastics. These natural movements, along with outdoor play, strength training, and balance activities, help develop these skills organically throughout childhood.

Today, many pediatric podiatrists now encourage children to wear flexible shoes, shoes with a wide toe-box so toes have room to spread, and less rigid support when appropriate. So, get the right size shoe for those growing feet!

The Functional Nutrition Approach:

From a functional nutrition perspective, healthy toes are not just about the toes themselves — they reflect the health of the entire body, including circulation, nerves, muscles, connective tissue, bones, inflammation, blood sugar regulation, and movement patterns. Since the feet and toes contain small muscles, tendons, ligaments, joints, blood vessels, and sensory nerves, they are particularly vulnerable to poor nutrition, chronic inflammation, diabetes, aging, reduced circulation, and loss of muscle mass.

Key nutritional priorities may include adequate protein intake for muscle maintenance; minerals such as magnesium, calcium, potassium, and zinc for muscle and nerve function; omega-3 fats for inflammation balance; collagen-building nutrients including vitamin C; and optimal vitamin D levels for bone, muscle, and balance support. Stable blood sugar regulation is also critically important because chronically elevated glucose may damage nerves, circulation, connective tissue, and foot mechanics over time.

Hydration, movement, strength training, balance exercises, proper footwear, and toe mobility exercises also matter. Healthy toes thrive on circulation and movement. Walking, resistance training, balance work, barefoot foot-strengthening exercises (when safe), and toe-splaying exercises may help maintain intrinsic foot muscle function and sensory feedback to the brain.

Improving balance is extremely important because preventing falls helps reduce fracture risk. So, let's get to work on improving our balance, foot strength, walking confidence/gait stability, posture alignment, and fall resistance/prevention through some simple (*and yes, seemingly boring*) but effective toe exercises.



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Exercise Visual	Discussion
1. Toe Spreading (“Toe Splays”) 	Balance and Toe Control • Sit or stand barefoot • Spread toes apart as wide as possible • Hold 3–5 seconds • Bring toes back together and Relax Do: 10-15 repetitions Safety Cues: Don’t fret if you cannot do this... Most people (<i>Like me!</i>) initially cannot spread their toes much — that’s normal. Benefit: Helps foot muscle activation, balance, toe control, stability during walking. [14–16]
2. Toe Raises 	Strengthens muscles on top of your foot and improves toe ankle control • Stand holding a counter or chair You can also sit tall in a chair. • Keep flat on the floor. • Lift toes up toward you as high as you can, keeping heel on the ground • Slowly lower toes back down with control Do: 10-15 repetitions Safety Cues: keep ankles still; do not curl toes while lifting them up Benefit: Improves toe strength, ankle stability, balance, walking mechanics and fall prevention. [14–16]
3. Towel Scrunches 	Strengthen Intrinsic Foot Muscles • Place towel on floor • Use toes to pull towel towards you Do: 30-60 seconds each foot Safety Cues: Keep your heel on the floor. Use only your toes to pull the towel. Stop if you develop foot cramps or pain. Benefit: Strengthens tiny stabilizing muscles in foot [14–16] See below for more advanced options.



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Exercise Visual	Discussion
4. Heel Raises/Drops 	Strengthens lower legs + improves balance • Stand holding a chair • Lift heels → slowly lower Do: 2–3 sets of 10–15 reps daily or 3–5×/week (as tolerated). Safety Cues: Keep movements gentle; avoid if high fracture risk; hold support for balance; land softly Benefit: Strengthens calves, foot stabilizers, and ankle control. Very good for bone loading. (See presentation on Osteopenia and Osteoporosis.)

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WHAT IF YOUR TOES DON'T MOVE APART?

If you've had a bunionectomy, have a rod installed, or your toes are stiff and won't splay, you can still strengthen your feet and improve balance. The goal is not to force movement, but to gently activate the muscles you can.



ALTERNATIVE 1: PRESS DOWN



Press your toes gently down into the floor and hold 3–5 seconds. Repeat 10 times.

ALTERNATIVE 2: BIG TOE LIFT



Try lifting just your big toe while the others stay down. Repeat 10 times.

ALTERNATIVE 3: TOWEL SCRUNCHES



Use your toes to scrunch a towel toward you. 30–60 seconds.

ALTERNATIVE 4: SHORT FOOT



Gently shorten your foot (pull the ball of your foot back toward your heel without curling toes). Hold 5 seconds. Repeat.



Consistency is key! Even small movements can improve foot strength, balance, and stability over time.

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How To Train Your Dragon... I Mean Your Toes

HOW TO TRAIN YOUR TOES TO SPREAD (TOE SPPLAYING)

Many people can't spread their toes at first. That's normal! You build control just like any other muscle.

The goal is not to force your toes apart, but to retrain the small muscles in your feet. Go slowly and be consistent.

KEY PRINCIPLES

- Start small.
- Move one toe at a time.
- Use daily short practice.
- Focus on control, not strength.
- Over time, your toes learn to move independently.

PROGRESSIVE TRAINING PLAN

Practice 5–10 minutes daily.

1 AWARENESS (Week 1–2)

Learn to move your toes one at a time.



Sit and look at your foot. Try lifting just your big toe while the others stay down. Then try each little toe. Repeat 5–10 times each toe.

2 ISOLATION (Week 2–4)

Improve control with small movements.



Lift one toe slightly, hold 2–3 seconds, then lower. Repeat for each toe.

3 ENGAGEMENT (Week 4–6)

Start to gently spread your toes.



Place your foot flat. Try to gently spread your toes apart. Hold 3–5 seconds. Repeat 5–10 times.

4 STRENGTH (Week 6+)

Increase hold time and control.



Hold the spread position 5–10 seconds. Repeat 5–10 times. Do daily.

EXERCISES TO BUILD TOE CONTROL

TOWEL SCRUNCHES



Use your toes to scrunch a towel toward you. 30–60 seconds. Helps activate foot muscles.

MARBLE PICK-UPS



Pick up marbles one at a time. Start with 5–10. Great for toe control.

TOE LIFTS



Lift all toes up, then relax. 10–15 reps. Improves toe strength.

SHORT FOOT



Gently pull the ball of your foot back (arch lifts). Hold 5 seconds. 5–10 reps.

WHAT IF YOUR TOES WON'T MOVE APART?

After surgery, bunionectomy, or with a rod installed, toe movement can be limited. You can still strengthen and improve function.

- Focus on what you CAN move.
- Build strength, even without full splay.
- Consistency improves flexibility over time.

PRESS DOWN



Press all toes down into the floor. Hold 3–5 seconds. Repeat 10 times. Builds strength and stability.

BIG TOE LIFT



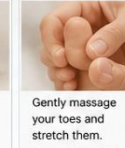
Try lifting just the big toe. Hold 2–3 seconds. Repeat 10 times. Improves control.

TOE SPREAD ASSIST



Use a toe spacer or towel roll between toes. Wear for a few minutes daily. Helps alignment and mobility.

MASSAGE & STRETCH



Gently massage your toes and stretch them. Improves mobility and flexibility.



BE PATIENT

Toe muscles are small and need time. Most people notice improvement in 2–6 weeks.



CONSISTENCY IS KEY

Short daily practice is more effective than long occasional sessions.

IMPORTANT

Never force your toes. Stop if you feel pain. Work within your comfort and ability.

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Remember, your feet need strength, mobility, and awareness. You can train your feet and toes *(as shown above)* – just like any other muscle in the body. Exercises such as short foot activation *(See next image)*, toe spreading, toe raises, towel scrunches, and marble pickups are commonly used in podiatric and physical therapy rehabilitation to strengthen the intrinsic muscles of the feet, improve arch stability, enhance toe control, and support balance and gait mechanics. [14–16] A simple daily routine when done consistently to improve steadiness over time and ONLY takes only 5 minutes a day: *(Excuse me... You say you don't have 5 minutes to help your body maintain balance?? You can do this while brushing your teeth! Easy Peasy. Right?! 😊)*

1. Toe spreads — 10 reps
2. Toe raises — 10 reps
3. Heel raises — 10 reps
4. March in place — 30 sec
5. Single-leg stand — 20 sec each side



Bonus Foot Exercise:

SHORT FOOT EXERCISE

What if you can't do it (yet)?

CAN'T DO IT?

If you're unable to lift your arch without curling your toes, lifting your heel, or feeling pain, your foot muscles may be weak, stiff, or not yet aware.

That's okay—start with these progressions.



PROGRESSIONS: BUILD AWARENESS & STRENGTH

- 1 Toe Relaxation**
Practice keeping toes long, relaxed, and spread.

- 2 Doming (Seated)**
Gently lift your arch while keeping toes and heel down.

- 3 Doming with Towel**
Practice doming while your foot is supported on a rolled towel.

- 4 Short Foot (Assisted)**
Use your hand or a band to help guide the arch up.


COMMON LIMITATIONS

- Weak intrinsic foot muscles
- Limited ankle or big toe mobility
- Overactive toe flexors (curling)
- Poor foot awareness
- Previous injury or pain

These are common—and reversible with consistent practice.

TIPS FOR SUCCESS

- ✓ Practice daily—start with just 1–2 minutes.
- ✓ Go slow—quality over quantity.
- ✓ Focus on small, gentle movements.
- ✓ Expect progress in weeks, not days.
- ✓ If you feel cramping or pain, back off and try an easier variation.

WHEN TO SEEK HELP

See a foot or movement specialist if you have:

- Pain in your foot, arch, or ankle
- Numbness or tingling
- Past injury or surgery
- Difficulty walking or balancing



REMEMBER: Your foot needs strength, mobility, and awareness.
You can train it—just like any other muscle in your body.

PROGRESS TAKES TIME—BE PATIENT & CONSISTENT

Awareness (Week 1–2) → Activation (Week 2–4) → Control (Week 4–8) → Strength & Endurance (Week 8+) → Stronger Feet Better Balance Less Pain

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Concluding Remarks

Healthy feet and toes are about far more than comfort — they are deeply connected to balance, posture, mobility, strength, confidence, independence, and quality of life as we age. From a functional nutrition perspective, the feet reflect the health of the entire body, including the nervous system, muscles, bones, circulation, inflammation levels, blood sugar regulation, and movement patterns. In other words... **everything is connected.**

The body has an incredible ability to respond to consistent nourishment, movement, strengthening, and balance training — even as we age. Proper nutrition, movement, balance training, supportive footwear, toe exercises, strength-building, and healthy lifestyle habits may all help support stronger feet, improved stability, and better mobility throughout life. It may be easy to overlook our “little piggies,” but they quietly help support us every single day from the ground up.

From a Biblical perspective, caring for our feet — including our toes — may also be viewed as part of stewarding the body God entrusted to us. *“Whether therefore ye eat, or drink, or whatsoever ye do, do all to the glory of God”* (1 COR 10:31, KJV). Sometimes healthy living truly does begin from the ground up.



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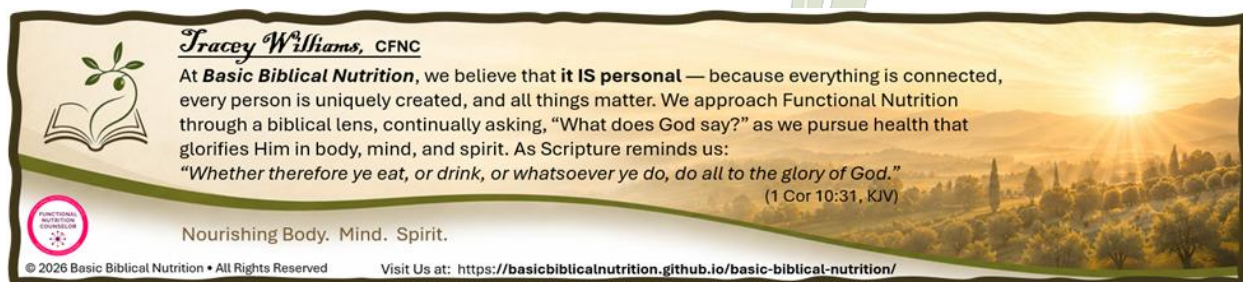
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Reference material available upon request.

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Tracey Williams is not a medical doctor. She is a Certified Functional Nutrition Counselor/Researcher. Tracey Williams does not diagnose or treat any medical illness or condition.



 **Tracey Williams, CFNC**

At **Basic Biblical Nutrition**, we believe that **it IS personal** — because everything is connected, every person is uniquely created, and all things matter. We approach Functional Nutrition through a biblical lens, continually asking, “What does God say?” as we pursue health that glorifies Him in body, mind, and spirit. As Scripture reminds us:

“Whether therefore ye eat, or drink, or whatsoever ye do, do all to the glory of God.”
(1 Cor 10:31, KJV)

Nourishing Body. Mind. Spirit.

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